

12.6.2023

Action plan to follow up the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment (ARRA)

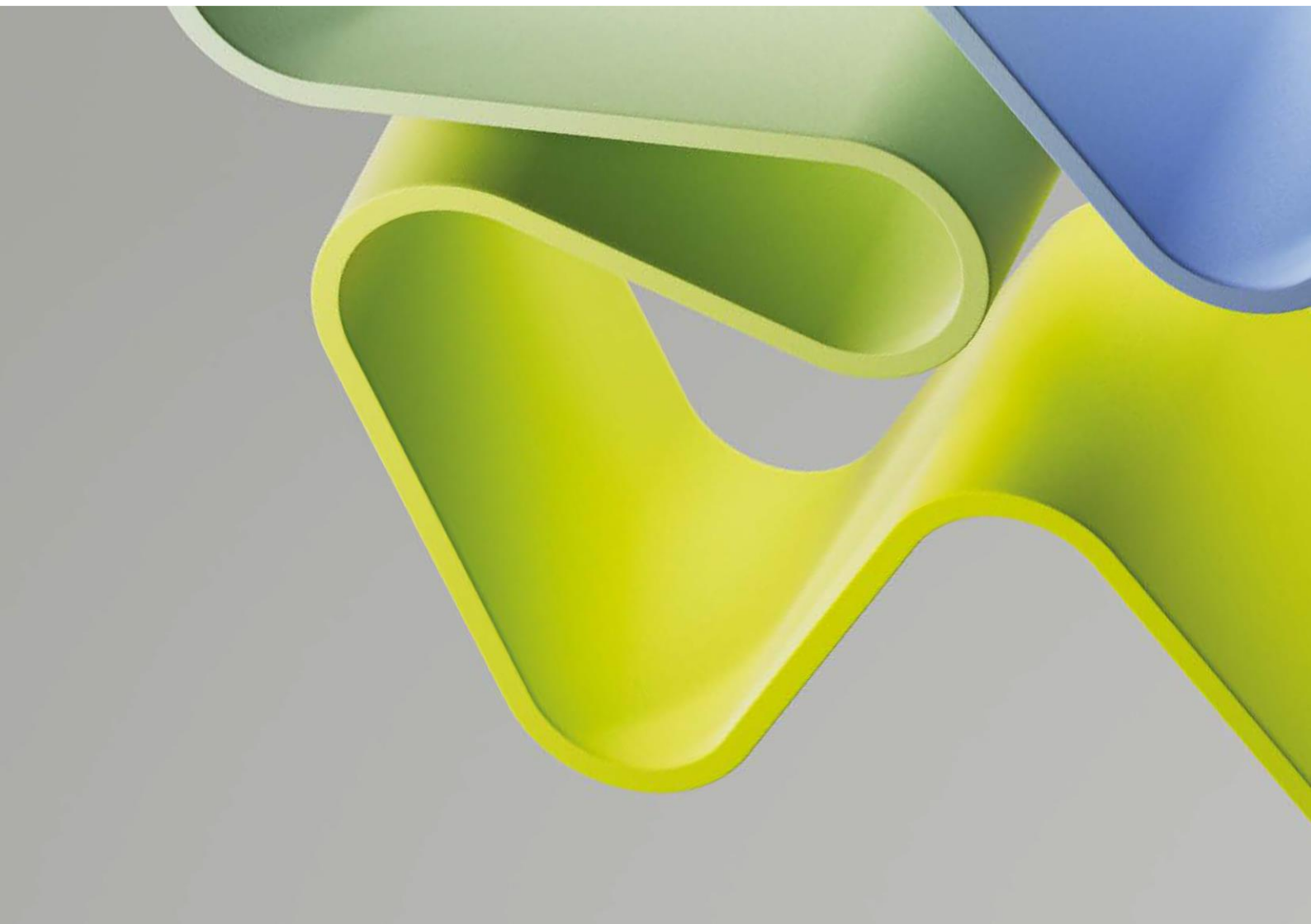


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1. Introduction

The Research Council signed the "Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment" (ARRA) in August 2022. The agreement sets a common direction for changes in assessment practices for research, researchers, and research-performing organisations, with the overall goal of maximising the quality and impact of research and ensuring a well-functioning research system. An important element of the agreement is to recognize the diversity of careers in research. The agreement states that the assessment of research and researchers should be based on qualitative evaluation systems where peer review is central, and with responsible use of quantitative indicators. The Research Council participates in the coalition of organisations that have signed ARRA with the aim of further developing and piloting new assessment criteria, methods, tools and data sources.

The purpose of the action plan:

The purpose of the internal action plan is to identify obligations in ARRA and to provide an overview of measures the Research Council has already implemented, in addition to proposing what should be done in the future. The action plan also provides an overview of national and international initiatives in which the Research Council is involved, which have synergies with ARRA.

2. Obligations in ARRA

Signatories to ARRA undertake to:

- Allocate resources to improve assessments of research and researchers
- Assess and develop criteria, tools and processes with a focus on flexibility and that different institutions have different needs
- Engage in knowledge sharing with the reform's signatories
- Conduct training and training in their own business

The timetable for implementing the reform is described as follows:

- One year after signing (August 2023), the Research Council must report on its plans for reform work
- By the end of 2027, the Research Council will have reviewed and evaluated its assessment processes and criteria in accordance with the principles and objectives of the reform

2.1. How RCN will follow up ARRA

The Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) was established in December 2022 and consists of all institutions and organizations that have signed the ARRA. All institutions that have signed the agreement are represented in the General Assembly. The General Assembly determines the governance of the coalition, elects the president and the board of directors of the coalition, including the coalition secretariat. It also approves the annual work plans and budget (prepared by the Secretariat), and the procedures and criteria for the operation of various working groups (proposed by the Board of Directors). The Research Council has selected a representative to participate in the meetings of the General Assembly. Working groups have been established to work on specific topics related to ARRA. The RCN has established a dialogue with the higher education institutions through the national NOR-CAM-network about which working groups Norwegian institutions participate in. Currently the RCN participates in the following working group: "Improving practices in the assessment of research proposals."

By signing the agreement, the Research Council undertakes to report on how we have started the process of reviewing and developing our criteria, instruments and processes in line with the agreement within one year of signing (i.e. August 2023). The initiatives that RCN is working with or has already implemented are listed in the table in chapter 4.

2.2. International initiatives where RCN is involved

- **Science Europe:** The Research Council participates in several working groups, of which two are particularly relevant for the work related to ARRA – the Working Group on Research Culture and the Working Group on Open Science. It is expected that these two working groups will continue to provide input to the further work in COARA and with the implementation of the agreement.
- **The San Francisco Declaration on Research Assessment (DORA)**
- **NOR-CAM – Guidelines for academic careers** – The Research Council of Norway has participated in the working group that drafted the NOR-CAM guidelines in 2019. A starting point for the working group was the agreed understanding of the needs for change in how researchers and research are assessed in the light of open science. The working group has worked in close collaboration with similar processes in several other European countries. Universities Norway has formed a national network for the implementation of the guide at the higher education institutions. The Research Council participates as an observer in the network. The implementation of NOR-CAM is a direct implementation of ARRA and thus Norway is at the forefront in this field. NOR-CAM has been approved as a National Chapter by the CoARA Steering Board.

- **Research on research institute (RoRI)** - The Research Council of Norway was a strategic partner in RoRI's pilot phase 2020-2022. Participation is coordinated from the Department of Data Management and Analysis. From 2023, the Research Council has decided to participate in three projects, where the *A Global Observatory of Responsible Research Assessment* (AGORRA) project is of particular interest. The focus of the project is on the development of national research evaluations, such as the Norwegian subject evaluations. In addition to the Research Council, NIFU participates in the project, funded by the research centre R-quest (FORINNPOL)

3. Measures implemented by the RCN

3.1. Application assessment

The Research Council signed DORA in 2018 and as a result, several adjustments were made to the application processing process ([DORA declaration \(forskingsradet.no\)](https://forskingsradet.no/dora)):

- In panel assessments, panels must consider the project application and CV of the project participants as one of four other criteria. It is pointed out that it is the project's content that has the main focus.
- Emphasis will be placed on the quality rather than quantity of publications – In the CV template, the project participants can attach their 10 most relevant publications
- Journal Impact Factor (JIF) should not be used in the assessment
- In the CV template, research results other than publications can be reported, such as data, software and other activities of societal relevance

The RCN has included open science as part of the assessment criterion for "Impact" in calls for proposals in 2023 onwards. This is in line with ARRA. In connection with this, a guide was prepared for referees and applicants on open science in Impact and effects, how this should be understood and assessed: [Assessment of open science in grant applications \(forskingsradet.no\)](https://forskingsradet.no/open-science)

3.2. Evaluation of research and researchers

RCN will produce a Guide for Responsible and Inclusive Evaluation that deals with how evaluation contributes to different policy areas and research policy goals (disadvantages and advantages in evaluation design for users) – with cases from subject evaluations and level division into counting edges up to DORA. This will have the status of an internal document.

In further work on the follow-up of ARRA, the Research Council will clarify the distinction between evaluation of the Research Council's policy instruments (which in principle fall outside the scope of the agreement) and evaluation of research and researchers (covered by the agreement). Policy instrument evaluations will primarily relate to the financial regulations in the central government and established standards for evaluation. However, it may be relevant to assess whether data and methods used in policy instrument evaluations are suitable for promoting or inhibiting the implementation of ARRA.

3.3. Monitoring open science

In order to gain insight into the effect of the Research Council's measures and policy work, it is necessary to monitor open research practices in the research system, for example by obtaining an overview of articles, data, DMPs, source code and software that are made available in line with the principles of open science. A monitoring system should be established to document the effect of the Research Council's requirements and developments in the research communities. In 2023, the Research Council introduced a new expert criterion for open research practice as part of the assessment criterion for impact. The monitoring of open research should be linked both to the new assessment criterion and to more general requirements for data management plans, open publishing, access and storage of data, open source, etc. RCN will update the monitoring system for open science when revising its policy for access to research data (from 2017).

4. Priorities and timetable for 2023-2027

Ongoing
 Tentative
 Conducted

Effort	2023	2024	2025	2026	2027
1. Finalize the draft internal action plan					
2. Input, comments and anchoring of the action plan in area management meetings and cases in HM					
3. Participation in the NOR-CAM network					
4. Participation in COARA's Annual General Meeting					
5. Provide input to working groups and clarify the Research Council's participation in working groups (CoARA)					
6. Follow-up research project in collaboration with NIFU on RRA in the subject evaluations					
7. Produce guidelines for responsible and inclusive evaluation					
8. CV template development related to the development of a new ICT system					
9. Implement a holistic approach to research ethics					
10. Implement monitoring for open research results, measure the impact of our requirements					
11. Evaluate changes in assessment processes, including a new CV template					
12. Changes in application assessment (AI and automation) in connection with new ICT system					
13. Prepare a protocol with criteria and data basis for new subject evaluations					
14. Evaluate new instruments and ongoing application processes					

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